

Grown-up tree

The tree has reached full height when it's between 500 and 750 years old.

By this time, it has also changed shape. While the top of the trunk is laden with branches, the lower part has none. The tree can survive for more than 2,500 years.

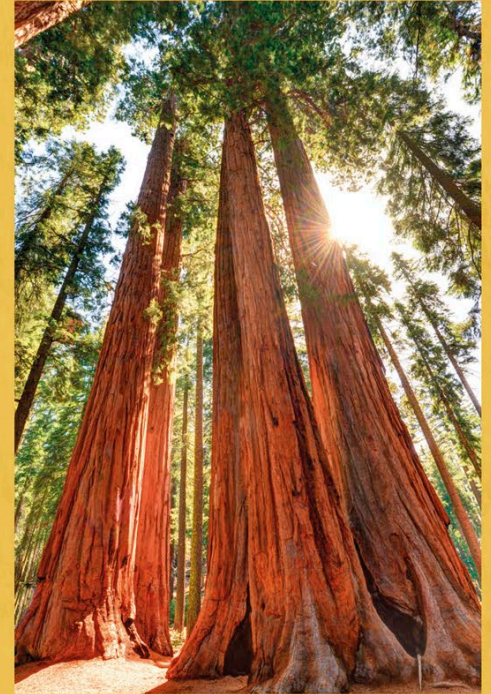
The bark doesn't burn easily and is very thick—up to 3 ft (1 m). This helps the tree resist fire.

Old age and death

Fierce storms can cause an old sequoia tree to fall over and die. Another cause of death is lack of water because of drought.

Once dead, the tree eventually breaks up and becomes part of the soil on the forest floor.

Under threat Despite their thick bark, giant sequoias can be destroyed by disease or forest fires spreading between their branches. It takes a long time for giant sequoias to reproduce, and other, faster-growing trees can take their place in the forest.



Animal life Some animals, including birds, owls, and bats, visit the fallen giant sequoia and feed from the bark and the roots. This pileated woodpecker is pecking into tree bark in search of insects.



The trunk can be up to 30 ft (9 m) wide.

The massive root system is not that deep but is wide enough to help the sequoia stay balanced.

Mosses and fungi can grow on the dead wood.

2,500 years old